

Balsam of Peru



What is it?

Balsam of Peru is a natural substance used to screen for fragrance and/or flavoring allergy. It is obtained from the bark of a tree found in Central America. It has a sweet scent of cinnamon and vanilla, and is antibacterial.

If you have a balsam of Peru allergy, you should avoid fragrance. Products with the terms *natural*, *unscented*, *hypoallergenic*, and *fragrance free* are not regulated and thus may contain fragrance. Do not trust these labels. However, know that true *fragrance-free* products do exist.

Balsam of Peru contains many contact allergens such as:

- Benzoic acid
- Benzyl alcohol
- Benzyl benzoate
- Benzyl cinnamate
- Benzyl isoferulate
- Cinnamic acid
- Cinnamic alcohol
- Cinnamyl cinnamate
- Coniferyl alcohol
- Coniferyl benzoate
- Eugenol
- Farnesol
- Ferulic acid
- Isoeugenol
- Limonene
- Nerolidol
- Vanillin

BALSAM OF PERU can also be known as:

- *Myroxylon pereirae* resin
- Balsam Peru

- Peru balsam
- Peruvian balsam
- Oleoresin
- Balsamum peruvianum
- Black balsam
- China oil
- Honduras balsam
- Indian balsam
- Peruvian balsam
- Surinam balsam

Some Possible Uses of BALSAM OF PERU / FRAGRANCE / Where it might be found:

Personal Care Products

- Shampoo, conditioner, hair tonic, oil, gel, mousse, spray, pomade
- Liquid and bar soaps, cleansers
- Cream, lotion, oil
- Anti-aging cream
- Make-up, make-up remover, toner
- Sunscreen, sunless tanner
- Deodorant, anti-perspirant
- Shaving lotion, after shave
- Shaving cream, gel
- Hair removal cream
- Perfume, cologne, body mist
- Hygiene spray, rinse
- Powder (body, talcum, baby, foot)
- Baby wipes, moist wipes
- Toothpaste, mouth wash, dental items
- Analgesic rub
- Ointment (i.e. diaper or medicated)
- Sanitary napkins, light pads
- Facial tissue, toilet paper
- Candles and incense
- Essential oil (i.e. diffused), aroma therapy

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Medical Items

- Surgical scrub
- Wound and burn care, anti-septics
- Medicated cream, spray
- Chinese or cassia oil
- Tincture of benzoin

Household Items

- Detergent (i.e. dish, laundry)
- Fabric softener, dryer sheet
- Cleaning sprays and wipes
- Plug-in fragrances, potpourri
- Air freshening sprays, Car freshener
- Anti insect and pest products
- Paint, paint thinner, turpentine
- E cigarettes, scented or flavored tobacco
- Air vent systems (i.e. casinos, hotels)

Other substances that may cross-react with BALSAM OF PERU / FRAGRANCE:

- Beeswax, propolis
- Colophony
- Benzyl salicylate
- Benzyl alcohol
- Wood tar
- Essential oils
- Tincture of benzoin
- Camphor
- Fragrance, aroma, perfume, parfum

What should I do to avoid BALSAM OF PERU?

Balsam of Peru is not usually used “as-is” in products, so you will not see this word on labels.

It is best to avoid all fragranced products. Look for the words fragrance, aroma, perfume, parfum, and other fragrance chemical names. Any ingredient which sounds like a flower or plant

could worsen your rash. Even *unscented* or *fragrance-free* products can contain masking fragrance. *Hypoallergenic* products may also not be safe.

Look at the ingredients of each product you use for fragrance, parfum/perfume, plant or botanical names. For products already at home with no ingredients, go to the store and inspect the original box or package or look at the manufacturer’s or store’s website.

Your exposure to fragrance may be from contact with a partner who uses an item with fragrance.

If you are very allergic to Balsam of Peru, you may have to avoid airborne fragrance. For example, candles, incense, and plug-ins.

To identify possible workplace exposure, check the ingredients of each product. Sometimes a small amount of fragrance is present even though not listed. You may need to contact the manufacturer to learn if a product contains fragrance. Material Safety Data Sheets (MSDS) often do not include the full list of ingredients in a product. Substitute fragrance-free alternatives, or wear rubber or vinyl gloves.

Reference:

Contact Dermatitis 2019;80(6):335-353.

In addition, the ACDS Contact Allergen Management Program® (CAMP®) can help manage contact dermatitis. It helps to find products that are safe to use by creating a list of products that do not contain one's allergens. For more information about CAMP®, please ask your doctor or visit www.contactderm.org.

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